

Indigenous Population Perception of Environmental Restoration Programs in the Pátzcuaro Lake Basin



Authors: María Guadalupe García Alonso, Diego Maximiliano Macall
Contact: mar.garcia.al26@gmail.com



Introduction

The Lake Pátzcuaro basin is one of the most important bodies of water in Mexico. Culturally, the lake's basin is the birthplace of the Purépecha people. Purépecha ancestors are known for having maintained a balanced management of the natural resources in the basin (Fisher et al, 2003). They coexisted with, knew, and respected nature through practices and use of knowledge closely linked to their worldview, thereby forming a system of beliefs around the multiple uses of natural resources in the region.

Lake Pátzcuaro's basin is now under threat from climate change and the overextraction of resources. Local governments and the federal government have reacted by implementing different conservation and restoration schemes. This study registers the perceptions of the basin's indigenous inhabitants of the different environmental restoration schemes that have been undertaken over the last few decades.

Background

Lake Pátzcuaro is a picturesque and culturally significant freshwater lake located in the state of Michoacán, Mexico. It holds immense cultural and historical importance for the indigenous Purépecha people who have inhabited the region for centuries. The lake lies approximately 2,040 meters (6,700 feet) above sea level and covers an area of about 97 square kilometers (37 square miles), making it one of the largest natural lakes in Mexico. It is relatively shallow, with a maximum depth of around 12 meters (39 feet). The lake's depth can vary seasonally.

Lake Pátzcuaro is home to a diverse range of plant and animal species, including various fish species, waterfowl, and aquatic plants. Unfortunately, the lake has faced environmental challenges, including pollution and the introduction of non-native species, which have affected its ecosystem.

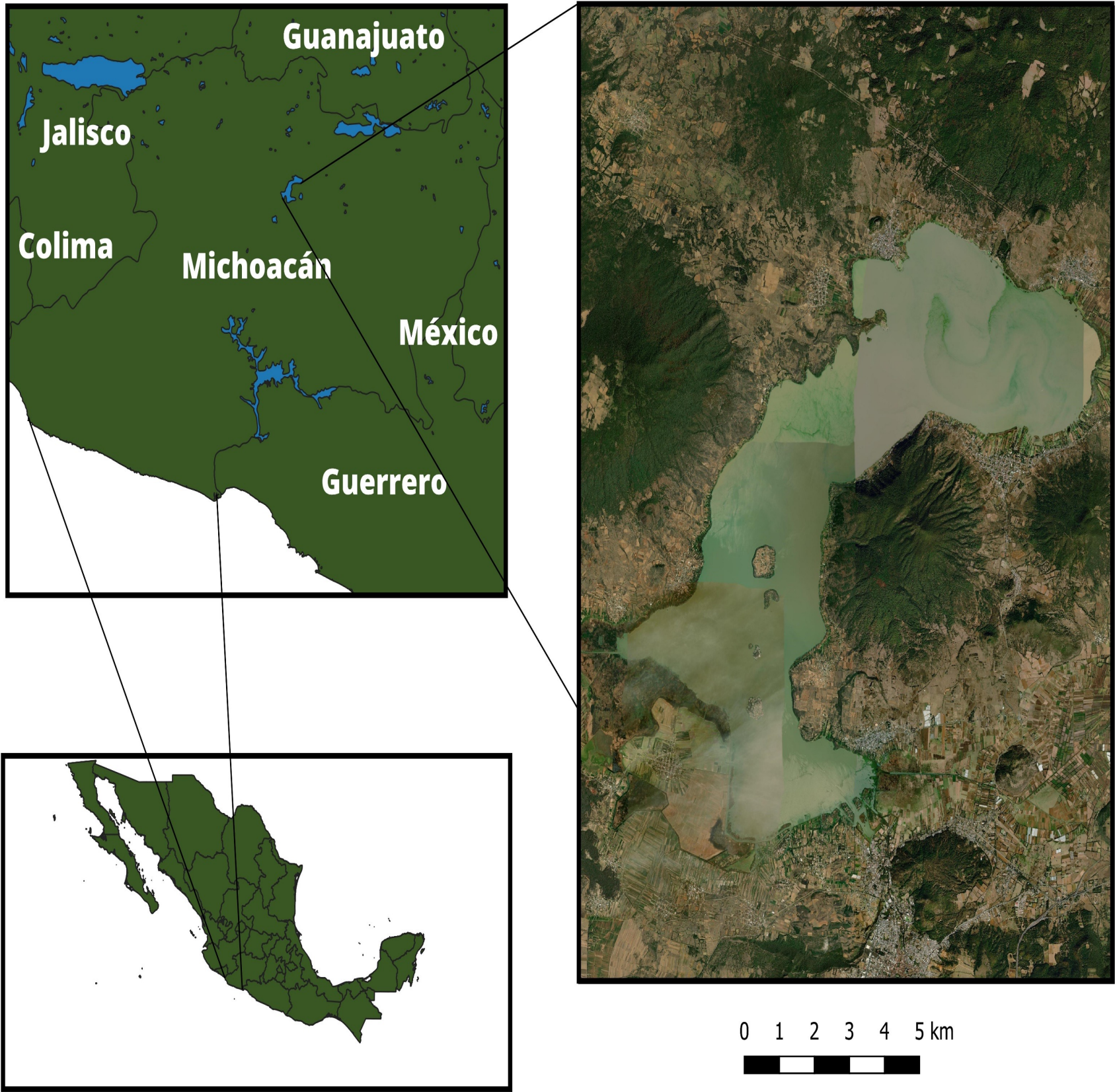


Figure 1. Lake Pátzcuaro's location within Mexico

Methodology

Two distinct methodologies will be used to register indigenous perceptions of environmental restoration programs in the Pátzcuaro Lake Basin. The qualitative approach will make use of semi-structured interviews done with people who live in (islands within the lake) and around the lake. The quantitative approach will analyze recollected data through descriptive statistics.

Results

Figure 2 shows the demographic information of the Lake Pátzcuaro basin. In all of the communities around Lake Pátzcuaro, though most of the inhabitants are indigenous, the proportion of them that speak Purépecha is significantly lower. Santa Fe de la Laguna has the most inhabitants.

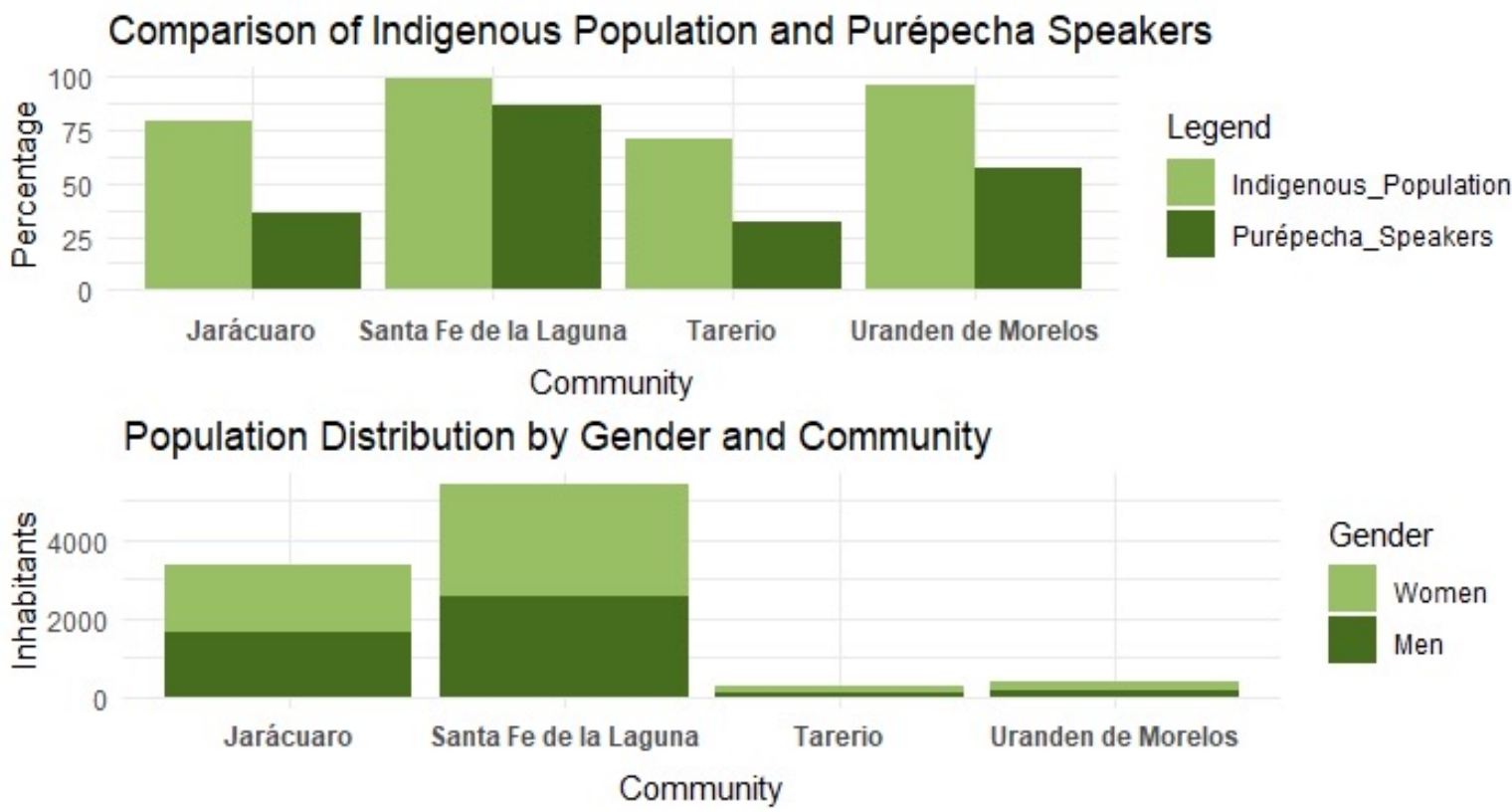


Figure 2. Communities around Lake Pátzcuaro demographic composition

Source: Authors based on INEGI 2020

Though climate change has caused part of Lake Pátzcuaro to dry out, some inhabitants do not perceive this as something negative because they are able to do agriculture there now.

Conclusion (Preliminary)

The knowledge accumulated over generations by the indigenous population of the Lake Pátzcuaro basin has largely been omitted from the policies and programs aimed at environmental restoration. Furthermore, those interviewed state that restoration programs are not followed through and are subject to change when local governments or the federal government change, and lack institutional coordination.

An inclusive and participatory 'bottom-up' approach would benefit any restoration or conservation policies in the basin.

References

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